MONGOL–JAPANESE WARS

FAILED MONGOL INVASION OF JAPAN



Date June–August 1281
Forces Mongols: 4,400 ships: Japanese: unknown
Losses Mongols: c.3,000 ships

Location
Tsushima Strait

The Mongol emperor of China, Kublai Khan, demanded that the Japanese acknowledge his suzerainty. In 1274 he raided Japan, sending a substantial force across from Korea to land in Hakata Bay. The attack failed to cow the Japanese, but it did stimulate them to organize new coastal defences. In 1281 Kublai mounted a full-scale invasion, assembling more than 4,000 ships from China and Korea to carry some 150,000 troops. The 900 Korean ships were thoroughly seaworthy vessels, but the Chinese ones were mostly flat-bottomed river or coastal craft. Kublai's fleet formed two squadrons, the smaller sailing from Korea and the larger from northern China. The force from Korea arrived first, but was unable to land its soldiers because of the coastal fortifications built and manned by the Japanese since 1274.

Anchored offshore, the Mongols were harassed by Japanese samurai in small craft, who set fire to ships and killed crew and soldiers. The Mongols withdrew to Iki island to rendezvous with the squadron from China. They then attacked Takashima island, while the Japanese awaited an assault on the mainland. The invasion never came, however, for a typhoon—known to the Japanese as the "divine wind" or "kamikaze"—struck the Mongol fleet, sinking most of the Chinese ships.



Hit-and-run tactics
Before the Mongol invasion fleet was struck by a typhoon, it was attacked by waves of attacks by samurai archers in fast, light boats.

FALL OF THE YUAN DYNASTY

LAKE POYANG



Date August 30–September 2,1363
Forces Ming: unknown; Han: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location
Lake Poyang, China

By the mid-14th century the rule of the Yuan dynasty in China was disintegrating. Rebel peasant bands known as the Red Turbans took control of the Yangtze River region, and two of their leaders, Chen Youliang and Zhu Yuanzhang, became rivals for power. Chen declared himself emperor and founder of the Han dynasty. Zhu, leader of the Ming, ruled a large area of southern China from his capital city, Nanjing. The war between them lasted from 1360 to 1363, climaxing in a large-scale naval battle on China's largest freshwater lake, Lake Poyang.

Zhu Yuanzhang voyaged up the Yangtze from Nanjing with a large number of ships to confront the Han fleet blockading Ming forces in the lakeside town of Nanchang. Some sources claim that a million men were present in the two fleets, making this possibly the largest naval battle in history, although such immense figures have to be doubted. Chen Youliang had the largest vessels, three-decked "tower ships" propelled by sails and oars, with high sterns and iron-armored turrets. The Ming ships were smaller but more numerous and maneuverable, many of them treadmill-powered paddle ships.

The lake battle lasted four days. The initial Ming attack came close to disaster. Zhu's flagship ran aground on a sandbank and was set on fire by incendiary weapons. His other ships rescued him, but Ming attempts to close and board Han vessels failed. On the second day, Zhu exploited a favorable wind to send in fire ships—small boats packed with straw and gunpowder. These had considerable success against the tower ships, whose deep draft limited their mobility in the shallow waters of the lake. After a day spent on repairs, battle was resumed on September 2. This time the Ming ships penetrated the weakened Han formation and a number of ships were boarded and taken.

The battle ended inconclusively and there followed a month-long stand-off between the two fleets. In a skirmish on October 4, Chen Youliang was shot through the head with an arrow and killed. The Han cause collapsed without its leader. Zhu Yuanzhang went on to overthrow the Yuan and founded the Ming dynasty four years later.